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NOACH'S JOKES & RIDDLES

By: Noach Isaacs

What be a pirate's favorite letter?

ou may think it's R. But really it's the C!

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COMMUNITY CORNER

PARSHAS

VAYIGASH ויגש



SHABBOSS STARTS: **4:15 PM**
(18 MINUTES)

SHABBOSS ENDS: **5:24 PM**
(50 MINUTES)

TZAIS HAKOCHAVIM: **5:45 PM**
(72 MINUTES)

Editor-in-chief: Doni Stern
Made possible by contributing writers throughout our community.

STORY OF THE WEEK By: Zechariah Lipitz



(Reprinted from the N'Shei Chabad Newsletter)

It was 1979, two years before the Iranian Revolution. Rabbis Sholom Ber H. Illulian went to Iran from New York at the request of the Rebbe. As part of their mission, they delivered a Tanya, the basic book of Chabad Chasidic philosophy, to Iran's Jewish spiritual leader, Rabbi Yehuda Ezechian. One month later, Rabbi Ezechian received a telephone call from Rabbi J.J. Hecht, who had been very involved in efforts to bring as many Iranian Jews as possible to safety in the United States. Rabbi Hecht relayed the Rebbe's instructions to print Tanyas for the Jews in Iran. By then, most of the Jewish population had fled Iran. It was an extremely dangerous place to live. But Rabbi Ezechian remained at his post as head of the Jewish community in Iran and the leader of the Rabbinical Court for three more years. The Iranian Moslem Ministers, under the brutal and ruthless Khomeini, issued an edict whose purpose was to purge Iran of anything connected with the Shah of Iran, and to disobey meant a charge of treason and death. Rabbi Ezechian had narrowly escaped death several times already, since there was also a strict edict against anyone and anything that could be perceived to be helping the state of Israel. The death sentence was swiftly and unmercifully carried out upon anyone who dared to disobey that edict. But Rabbi Ezechian, a scholarly, G-d fearing man, and an ardent chasid of the Rebbe, had been instructed to print Tanyas for the Persian Jews. He did so, but since most of the Persian Jews could not read, write or understand Hebrew, Rabbi Ezechian was in the process of translating the Tanya into Persian. One day, Rabbi Ezechian was in the office of his synagogue, working on his translating of the Tanya. Suddenly there was loud, insistent banging on the door and the unmistakable shouts of the Iranian Taliban. These policemen were known to be violent fanatical Moslem ministers looking for some new Jewish blood to spill, just to prove how loyal they were to their Imam. When Rabbi Ezechian opened the door, his heart was racing so fast that he could not think. The office contained historical documents and items connected to the Shah. And worst of all, it was filled with the receipts of the money that people had given to him to donate for charity to Israel. If these receipts were now found, it would be considered aiding the enemy, the Zionist state - and he would surely be shot on the spot. Numbly, he stood there as the violent, screaming ministers burst into his office. They immediately started to pull open doors to closets and dump out files. Any minute they would find the receipts and then.... the rabbi understood what was about to take place and recited his final prayers. As the strength started to leave his body, Rabbi Ezechian prayed to G-d. He saw certain death before his eyes and prepared to meet his Maker. Suddenly, one of the ministers pounced on a Tanya. He leafed through it but of course could not read the Hebrew. Roughly he asked Rabbi Ezechian what it was, and what it said. "It is a holy book, and I am translating it into Farsi," stammered Rabbi Ezechian, praying silently that the merit of the Tanya would somehow save him. Opening the book at random, the radical ordered the pale, trembling rabbi to translate it exactly as it was written. Rabbi Ezechian did as he was told. He stood there and translated it faithfully, and after translating ten pages, he was quietly ordered to stop. The ministers, who had all stopped their raiding in order to listen, now stood in silent awe. Reverently, their leader took the Tanya, gently touched it to his eyes, and then kissed it. (A Persian custom to show respect). "A book like this we all need," he said. He sternly told everyone that they need search no longer, because it was obvious that they were with a man who honored "Allah." Moreover, a special edict was written to protect Rabbi Ezechian from any form of persecution in the future as well as to allow the Rabbi to continue to translate the holy book with no more disturbances! After they left, Rabbi Ezechian fell to the ground in a faint. He soon regained consciousness, but found it difficult, at first, to grasp the fact that he was still alive! They had not discovered the receipts, or the letters from Israel saying that they had received the moneys sent to them. Even just one of those documents would have meant certain death, let alone a full filing cabinet of them. They had listened respectfully to ten pages of Tanya in Farsi. And he had an edict of protection issued by the Taliban radicals themselves! On the following Shabbat, Rabbi Ezechian said the special "Gomel" prayer thanking G-d for saving him from death. Rabbi Ezechian visited the U.S. a few years later. At his first private audience with the Rebbe, tears rolled down Rabbi Ezechian's cheeks. The Rebbe told him, "Serve G-d with joy!" Rabbi Ezechian replied, "These are tears of happiness." They spoke together for a long time, and then Rabbi Ezechian said to the Rebbe, "The Jews in Iran are in physical danger, and the Jews who have left are in spiritual danger. I am so worried about them." Tears came to his eyes again when the Rebbe answered, "So let us pray for them together." They held each other's hands and prayed for the Iranian Jews. Rabbi Ezechian had many other private audiences with the Rebbe. Each time, he tried his utmost to fulfill what the Rebbe wanted from him. Rabbi Ezechian translated the Abridged Code of Jewish Law, the prayer book, Psalms, as well as five other books of the Bible. The Rebbe personally checked several of the translations, though not all. After leaving Iran, Rabbi Ezechian lived in Israel for a while before moving to Great Neck, New York.

PARSHA QUESTION By: Gavriel Grodtko

What finally convinced Yakov that Yoseph was indeed alive

Stay tuned for the answer in the next Community Corner issue
Answer to last weeks parsha question:

Q. How old was Yosef when he met Pharaoh?
A. 30

TEFILLAH OF THE WEEK

Hamavir Sheina
"Mizmor Lesoda- מזמור לתודה- הריעו לה' כלי הארץ - A psalm of thanksgiving: Shout for joy to Hashem everyone on earth -Serve Hashem with joy come before Him with exultation -Know that Hashem is God He has made us and we are His people and the sheep of His pasturing -Enter His gates with thanksgiving His courtyards with praise -Give thanks to Him, bless His Name -for Hashem is good His loving kindness is eternal and to every generation His faithfulness extends



MEGA VORT By: Yoel Megadesh

Parshas Vayigash. Perek 45. Pasuk 12.
Rashi explains that once Yosef began to speak to the Shevatim in Hebrew they believed that he was Yosef. The Ramban asks what proof is there that he was Yosef if he knew Hebrew, any king would normally know all the languages? We can answer this question with a different question. Why couldn't the brothers recognize Yosef from his voice? The Gemara (Chullin 96) states that you can recognize a person by their voice. The answer is that it is true that you can recognize someone by their voice, but that is only if they are speaking the language you always spoke to them in. Until now, Yosef was speaking to them in Egyptian with a translator in between. But now that he was speaking in Hebrew, they were really able to recognize him. (Reb Yehonasan Eyebeschitz)



THIS WEEK IN JEWISH HISTORY

Torah translated into Greek (246 BCE)
In a second attempt to translate the Torah into Greek (after an unsuccessful attempt 61 years earlier), the ruling Greek-Egyptian emperor Ptolemy gathered 72 Torah sages, had them sequestered in 72 separate rooms, and ordered them to each produce a translation. On the 8th of Tevet of the year 3515 from creation (246 BCE) they produced 72 corresponding translations, including identical changes in 13 places (where they each felt that a literal translation would constitute a corruption of the Torah's true meaning). This Greek rendition became known as the Septuagint, "of the seventy" (though later versions that carry this name are not believed to be true to the originals). Greek became a significant second language among Jews as a result of this translation. During Talmudic times, Tevet 8 was observed by some as a fast day, expressing the fear of the detrimental effect of the translation.

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